The Fun They Had

The big idea

Isaac Asimov's science-fiction story is set in the year **2157**. Eleven-year-old **Margie** studies alone at home with a **mechanical teacher**. When her friend **Tommy** (13) finds a real printed book about the schools of "centuries ago", Margie starts dreaming about how much fun children must have had learning together. The story makes us value what we already have: human teachers, classmates and real books.

GENRE

Science fiction imagines how science and technology might change life in the future. Asimov wrote this story in 1951, long before personal computers and online classes existed.

Summary

1. On **17 May 2157**, Margie writes in her diary that Tommy found a **real book**. Its pages were yellow and crinkly, and the words stood still instead of moving on a screen. Their grandparents' grandparents had read such books.
2. Margie hates school. Her mechanical teacher kept giving her geography tests and she was doing worse and worse. Her mother sent for the **County Inspector**, a little red-faced man, who took the teacher apart and found that the **geography sector was geared a little too quick**. He slowed it to an average ten-year level.
3. Tommy says the old book is about **school**, a special building where a **man** was the teacher and all kids of the same age learned the same things together.

4. Margie is surprised that a man could know enough to teach. She cannot imagine a stranger in her house teaching her.
5. Her mother calls her to school. Margie goes to her schoolroom next to her bedroom. Today's lesson is **arithmetic, the addition of proper fractions**. She puts her homework into the **slot** (written in a punch code she learnt at age six).
6. While the machine drones on, Margie thinks about the old schools, where children laughed and shouted in the schoolyard and went home together. She thinks about **"the fun they had."**

Characters

- **Margie**: curious, imaginative, lonely; dislikes the dull mechanical teacher and longs for company.
- **Tommy**: 13, a bit boastful and superior ("Because it's not our kind of school, stupid"), but knowledgeable.
- **The County Inspector**: cheerful and practical; he pats Margie's head and fixes the machine.
- **Margie's mother**: strict about regular school hours.

Themes

- **Human contact in learning**: a machine can give information, but it cannot give friendship, warmth or fun.
- **Technology's limits**: the teacher works perfectly as a machine, yet Margie is unhappy.
- **Irony**: we often complain about school; Margie envies exactly what we have.

KEY NUMBERS AND NAMES

Year 2157 · Margie 11, Tommy 13 · geography sector too quick · lesson on proper fractions · homework written in punch code.

MARGIE DOES NOT HATE LEARNING

She hates the **mechanical** way of learning, alone and without friends. Do not write that she was lazy.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Compare Margie's school with your school (5 marks). What did the Inspector do? Why did Margie hate school? Write a diary entry as Margie. Use value points: isolation, no peer group, rigid timing, no fun, human teacher understands feelings.

Quick recap

- Future school = machine teacher at home, alone, fixed hours.
- Old school = building, human teacher, classmates, fun.
- Message: technology cannot replace the human touch in education.

Practice questions

1. In which year does Margie write in her diary about the real book?
   (a) 2051 (b) 2155 (c) 2157 (d) 2517
2. Why did the County Inspector slow down Margie's mechanical teacher?
   (a) Its geography sector was geared a little too quick (b) Its history sector had blanked out (c) Margie had broken the punch-code slot (d) Her mother wanted more homework
3. What was Tommy's reaction when Margie asked about the book?
   (a) He gave the book to her as a gift (b) He refused to show it to her (c) He threw it away (d) He said it was about school, but not their kind of school
4. Which lesson did the mechanical teacher give Margie on the day of the story?
   (a) Geography (b) Addition of improper fractions (c) Addition of proper fractions (d) History
5. What surprised Margie most about the old schools?
   (a) That they had computers (b) That a man could be a teacher (c) That they had no homework (d) That they were open at night
6. The tone of the last line, "the fun they had", is mainly one of
   (a) anger (b) fear (c) longing (d) humour
7. Why did Margie hate school? What did she think of the old kind of school?
8. "Technology can never replace a human teacher." Discuss with reference to the story.

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. d 4. c 5. b 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes